

Vanderbilt - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | SEC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Above-average Power 4 / top-30 underlying quality, but one of the clearest high-variance regression profiles in the field because the elite 2025 offense is being rebuilt at quarterback, tight end and four offensive-line spots.
Preseason consensus	SP+ No. 29 (+9.8) · AP unranked, 8 points (others receiving votes) · SEC media poll 13th
Returning production	44% - No.103 overall · Off. 38% - No.117 · Def. 49% - No.81
Primer power rating	+10.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	6.3 wins · most likely 6-6
Net vs. 2025	● ↓ Worse - Worse. Vanderbilt is replacing the 2025 starting QB, second-round TE, four members of the season-long starting OL, a high-volume WR and multiple defensive contributors. Strong staff continuity and targeted transfers soften the drop but do not erase it.
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: OC Tim Beck keeps a physical, multiple offense but shifts more rushing work to the backs; DC Steve Gregory leans on a veteran LB core while QB/OL/TE and edge/secondary roles turn over.

Bottom line: Vanderbilt should remain competitive enough to make another bowl, but the roster has too much high-leverage turnover to price the Commodores as a simple continuation of the 10-win 2025 team.

Beats expectations if: QB Blaze Berlowitz provides efficient play while QB Jared Curtis adds useful early snaps, the unpublished OL five gels quickly, and the veteran LB/secondary core absorbs the edge turnover.

Disappoints if: The QB transition produces a major drop from QB Diego Pavia, the four-new-starter OL cannot protect obvious passing downs, and the departures of DL/EDGE Khordae Sydnor, EDGE Linus Zunk, EDGE Keanu Koht and multiple defensive backs turn an average-to-good 2025 defense into a clear weakness.

Five things to remember

- 1 QB decision:** Veteran QB Blaze Berlowitz will start the opener, while five-star freshman QB Jared Curtis is also expected to play.
- 2 2025 baseline:** Vanderbilt returns only 38% of offensive production (No.117) after a 2025 offense that ranked No.5 opponent-adjusted, No.2 in EPA/play and No.4 in success rate.
- 3 Offensive line:** Four 2025 starting OL are gone, and the staff has not publicly identified the full 2026 five.
- 4 Coaching:** HC Clark Lea, OC Tim Beck and DC Steve Gregory all return with play-calling continuity.
- 5 Schedule pressure:** The late Alabama → at Florida → Tennessee finish is a demanding three-game closing test after a schedule that already includes road trips to Auburn and Georgia.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	10-3 (6-2 SEC)	● Excellent
Scoring	38.5 PPG	● Elite
Total offense	463.1 YPG	● Elite
Rush offense	175.5 YPG · 5.6 YPC	● Good / above average
Pass efficiency	9.35 YPA · 30 TD / 8 INT	● Elite
Third downs	51.1%	● Elite
Scoring defense	22.8 PPG allowed	● Good / above average
Total defense	357.5 YPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Rush defense	108.2 YPG · 3.7 YPC	● Very good
Pass defense	249.4 YPG · 7.08 YPA · 24 TD allowed	● Below average

The 2025 offense was elite (No. 8 scoring, No. 9 total, No. 3 pass efficiency); the defense was No. 18 vs. the run but No. 100 by pass efficiency.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+10.84 · No. 5	● Elite
Off. EPA/play	+0.290 · No. 2	● Elite
Off. success rate	52.2% · No. 4	● Elite
Off. explosive-play rate	15.7% · No. 7	● Elite
Havoc allowed	13.3% · No. 35	● Very good
Opp.-adjusted defense	+3.08 · No. 37	● Good / above average
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.013 · No. 56	● Average / mixed
Def. success rate allowed	41.0% · No. 61	● Average / mixed
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	10.4% · No. 33	● Very good
Havoc created	17.5% · No. 28	● Very good

Advanced-stat read: The offense was genuinely elite (No. 5 adjusted, No. 2 EPA, No. 4 success, No. 7 explosiveness). Defense was solid rather than dominant, so 2026 depends more on limiting offensive regression than expecting the defense to carry the team.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Clark Lea - returning	● ↔ Preserves the program’s established identity and developmental structure.
OC / play-caller	Tim Beck - returning	● ↔ Tim Beck returns with offensive play-calling continuity around the established system.
DC / play-caller	Steve Gregory - returning	● ↔ Steve Gregory returns as defensive play-caller, keeping the scheme and game-day command intact.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ WR Cole Adams	Alabama	● ↔ Likely top-three WR and a meaningful replacement piece, but not yet proven as the lost 2025 volume equivalent.
◆ WR Ja'Cory Thomas	Old Dominion	● ↔ Expected top-three WR; raises replacement options behind WR Junior Sherrill but carries role/competition translation risk.
◆ C/OL Lyndon Cooper	Pittsburgh	● ↔ Material interior/center candidate in a line replacing four 2025 starters.

Out	To	Loss
QB Diego Pavia	NFL (Baltimore), undrafted free agent - waived	● ↓ The 2025 starting quarterback and Heisman runner-up leaves.
TE Eli Stowers	NFL (Philadelphia), Round 2, No. 54	● ↓ Second-round NFL departure removes the proven centerpiece of the 2025 tight-end passing game.
WR Tre Richardson	Louisville	● ↓ High-volume/high-impact 2025 receiver departs, increasing reliance on WR Junior Sherrill plus incoming WR Cole Adams and WR Ja'Cory Thomas.
OL Isaia Glass	NFL (Carolina), undrafted free agent	● ↓ 2025 starting-lineman departure contributes to a four-of-five starting OL rebuild.
C Jordan White	NFL (Jacksonville), undrafted free agent - retired	● ↓ 2025 starting center leaves; the later Reserve/Retired transaction is preserved as chronology rather than relabeled as eligibility.

Offensive net: ● ↓ clear downgrade from an elite 2025 unit, with enough skill additions and staff continuity to remain functional

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ EDGE Brian Allen Jr.	Iowa	● ↔ Projected with Miles Capers in the first edge pair.
◆ S Ricardo Jones	Clemson	● ↔ Adds safety rotation depth while the secondary replaces several contributors.

Out	To	Loss
DL/EDGE Khordae Sydnor	NFL (Cleveland), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Started all 13 games and had 8.5 sacks in 2025.
LB Langston Patterson	NFL (Dallas), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Veteran 69-tackle linebacker departure, partially buffered by the returning Longwell/Rinaldi/Cowan core.
DB Randon Fontenette	Colorado	● ↓ 13-game 2025 starter leaves a secondary that is already replacing multiple pro/eligibility departures.
S Marlen Sewell	NFL (Chicago), undrafted free agent	● ↓ A 52-tackle 2025 defender departs for the NFL.

Defensive net: ● ↓ moderate downgrade with the best continuity at linebacker and enough secondary incumbents to avoid a full rebuild

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Physical, multiple Beck offense blending clock-control/option elements with the faster and more explosive 2025 approach; 2026 emphasis shifts run burden toward the backs.	Staff continuity, a deep RB rotation and a WR group led by WR Junior Sherrill with transfer options around him.	Replacing Pavia plus four OL starters and Stowers at once; obvious passing downs are the stress point until QB/OL roles prove stable.
Defense	Gregory year-two continuity with opponent-specific adjustment and coverage manipulation rather than a system overhaul.	Veteran LB core; returning/reliable pieces at CB and safety; 2025 run defense and havoc/explosive prevention were solid.	Replacing the top pass-rush producer plus multiple edge and secondary departures without losing pressure or coverage consistency.
Special teams	Returning kicker with new candidates at punter and long snapper.	K Brock Taylor is an established returning kicker and Groza watchlist player.	P/LS turnover creates operation-level uncertainty even with transfer replacements on roster.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	Veteran QB Blaze Berlowitz will start the opener, with five-star freshman QB Jared Curtis also expected to play.
RB	● B	● ↔	Medium-high	RB Sedrick Alexander/RB Makhilyn Young headline a deep room expected to carry more rushing work.
WR	● B-	● ↓	Medium	WR Junior Sherrill is the top returning target, with transfer help replacing major 2025 volume.
TE	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	TE Jayvontay Conner and the current room must replace second-round NFL departure TE Eli Stowers.
OL	● C+	● ↓	Low	C/OL Lyndon Cooper is the clearest recognized anchor for a line replacing four 2025 starters.
DL/Edge	● B-	● ↓	Medium-low	EDGE Brian Allen Jr. joins a front replacing its top pass-rush producer and other contributors.
LB	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	LB Bryan Longwell/LB Nick Rinaldi/LB Bryce Cowan give the defense its strongest continuity.
Secondary	● B	● ↓	Medium	CB Martel Hight anchors a secondary that still must replace several starters/contributors.
Special teams	● B+	● ↔	Medium	K Brock Taylor is settled and Groza-recognized; punter/long snapper are changing.
Coaching	● A-	● ↔	High	HC Clark Lea, OC Tim Beck and DC Steve Gregory all return with play-calling continuity.
Overall	● B+	● ↓	Medium-low	Top-30 underlying quality with major regression risk from rebuilding QB, TE and four OL spots.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Junior Sherrill	WR	● High-end conference starter / primary-target candidate	Biletnikoff · Paul Hornung	Top returning WR and the safest known target in a pass-catcher group replacing major 2025 volume.
Jared Curtis	QB	● High-upside freshman changeup / future starter candidate	-	Will not start the opener but is expected to play; his development can still reshape the quarterback hierarchy.
Blaze Berlowitz	QB	● Unproven veteran starter	-	Named the opener starter after winning the preseason competition, though Jared Curtis is still expected to see action.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Sedrick Alexander	RB	● Solid Power 4 lead-back projection	-	Projects with Makhilyn Young atop a deeper RB room as Vanderbilt deliberately shifts more rushing work away from the quarterback.
◆ Lyndon Cooper (TR: Pittsburgh)	C/OL	● Important interior starter candidate	Rimington	The line replaces four starters; Cooper is the clearest recognized interior anchor signal, but exact alignment remains unresolved.
Bryan Longwell	LB	● High-end conference starter / veteran anchor	-	Part of the Longwell-Rinaldi-Cowan veteran linebacker core that provides the defense its strongest continuity.
Martel Hight	CB	● High-end conference starter / multipurpose athlete	Paul Hornung	One of the corners Vanderbilt explicitly expects to rely on while the secondary replaces several starters/contributors.
◆ Brian Allen Jr. (TR: Iowa)	EDGE	● Projected major-role edge replacement	-	Projected in the first edge pair as Vanderbilt replaces Khordae Sydnor and multiple other pass-rush contributors.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Difficult enough that a transition year can turn into a bowl-margin season even if Vanderbilt remains a top-30 team by underlying quality.
Difficulty	● 8/10 · Hard · SP+ SOS No. 24
Hardest stretch	Alabama → at Florida → Tennessee to close the regular season
Swing games	NC State, at Auburn, Ole Miss, Arkansas, at Kentucky, at Mississippi State
Advantage	Two nonconference home games open the season, and the lone bye comes Oct. 31 before the final four-game run.
Expected	6.3 wins · most likely 6-6
Floor / ceiling	4-8 / 8-4

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	The 10-win 2025 record is the obvious public anchor, while the 38% offensive returning-production rank and major QB/OL/TE departures argue for substantial regression. Treat Vanderbilt as a price-sensitive top-30 team, not as either a fraud or an automatic carryover contender.
Back them when	The market discounts Vanderbilt because of turnover but the QB/OL have stabilized, especially against comparable opponents where Beck can lean on the RB room and Gregory can dictate with a veteran linebacker core.
Fade/pass when	The price assumes 2025 offensive efficiency before the new QB/OL prove it, or when facing a strong pass rush/coverage unit capable of forcing the rebuilt offense into obvious passing situations.
Key monitor	Berlowitz/Curtis early snap distribution, exact offensive-line five/alignment, WR Junior Sherrill/WR Ja'Cory Thomas/WR Cole Adams availability, edge replacement production, punter/long-snapper roles
Week 1 baseline	vs. Austin Peay: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Vanderbilt –30.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Vanderbilt's 2025 breakthrough leaves a stronger program baseline, but the 2026 offense is not a continuation: QB Diego Pavia, TE Eli Stowers and four starting OL pieces are gone. Veteran QB Blaze Berlowitz will start the opener with five-star freshman QB Jared Curtis also expected to play, while major protection questions remain. RB Sedrick Alexander and WR Junior Sherrill give OC Tim Beck useful skill anchors, while the veteran LB core is the defense's best continuity point.

That profile supports a competitive but regression-prone team rather than another automatic 10-win contender. With **38% offensive returning production**, a hard closing schedule and a **6.3-win / 6-6** baseline, Vanderbilt is best treated as a price-sensitive top-30 team whose outlook improves materially if QB and OL stabilize early.

About this primer

DRWhittier · cfb.drwhittier.com · X: [@GatorBait7](https://twitter.com/GatorBait7) · Version 1.0 - August 25, 2026

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [camp update](#) · [roster roles](#) · [coaching](#) · [departures](#) · [current update](#) · [current update 2](#) · [QB1 update](#)

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